

RAMADHĀN:

WORSHIP OR RITUAL?

*Reflecting on the Misconceptions
of Ramadhān in Our Society*

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***In the Name of Allah,
the All-beneficent,
the All-merciful.***

Understanding the True Purpose of Ramadhān

Ramadhān is not just about abstaining from food and drink; it is a month of self-discipline, purification, and spiritual elevation. It is a sacred time that offers moral, intellectual, and social improvement.

However, when we compare the true Ramadhān (as described in the Qur'ān and by Ahl al-Bayt 'alayhimus-salām) with the way Ramadhān is practiced in the Subcontinent today, we see a significant difference. The essence of this holy month seems to have been lost in excessive cultural traditions, display of wealth, and spiritual negligence.

In this booklet, we will explore:

- What Ramadhān truly means according to the Qur'ān, Sunnah, and Ahl al-Bayt (‘alayhimus-salām).
- How Ramadhān is observed in the Subcontinent.
- The misconceptions and cultural practices that have altered its essence.
- Practical ways to revive the true spirit of Ramadhān.

By reflecting on these aspects, we can rediscover the true objectives of Ramadhān and prevent it from becoming just another ritual.

The True Purpose of Ramadhān

The Qur'ān describes Ramadhān as follows:

"The month of Ramadhān is that in which the Qur'ān was revealed, a guidance for the people and clear proofs of guidance and the criterion (between right and wrong)."

(Surah al-Baqarah 2:185)

This verse highlights two key aspects:

1. Ramadhān is a month of divine guidance.
2. It contains clear signs to distinguish truth from falsehood.

Every believer must pause and reflect on this message and strive

to understand the true objectives of Ramadhān.

Thus, Ramadhān is not just about abstaining from food and drink; rather, it is about:

- Strengthening our relationship with Allah (سُبْحَانَهُ وَتَعَالَى).
- Purifying the soul and disciplining the self.
- Deeply understanding and implementing the message of the Qur'ān.
- Recognizing social responsibilities and helping those in need.
- Promoting good character, patience, and gratitude.
- Standing firmly against all forms of injustice.

Imām Zayn al-‘Ābidīn (‘alayhis-salām) beautifully supplicates:

"O Allah! Help us to fast in such a way that our limbs abstain from Your disobedience, and remain engaged in acts that earn Your pleasure. Let our tongues speak truth, our ears avoid idle talk, and our hands and feet stay away from prohibited actions."

(Ṣaḥīfa al-Sajjādiyya)

This is the true Ramadhān—a month that teaches self-restraint, spiritual growth, and social justice. But the way Ramadhān is observed in the Subcontinent today often differs significantly from this ideal.

How Ramadhān is Practiced in the Subcontinent

Excessive Focus on Food and Overburdening Women

The True Ramadhān:

The Prophet Muḥammad (ṣallallāhu ‘alayhi wa-ālihi wa-sallam) and Ahl al-Bayt (‘alayhimus-salām) ate simple, light meals to maintain the spiritual nature of fasting.

Islam encourages moderation and warns against excessive indulgence:

"Eat and drink, but do not be excessive. Indeed, He does not like those who commit excess."

(Surah al-A‘rāf 7:31)

Our Ramadhān in the Subcontinent:

- Lavish ifṭār feasts filled with unhealthy and extravagant foods.
- Women spend hours preparing meals for suḥūr and ifṭār, reducing their time for prayer, Qur'ān, and spiritual growth.
- Some elders force children to eat excessively, believing it is a sign of good health, which can lead to digestive issues and unhealthy habits.
- More money is spent on food during Ramadhān than any other month!

Solution:

- Simplify meals and follow the example of the Prophet (ṣallallāhu 'alayhi wa-ālihi wa-sallam).
- Ensure women are not overburdened in food

preparation so they can also engage in worship.

- Avoid food wastage and share extra food with the needy.
- Ramadhān should be about spiritual nourishment, not indulgence.

The Misinterpretation of Sleeping as Worship

Many people believe that since the sleep of a fasting person is an act of worship, they can spend the entire day sleeping. This misunderstands the purpose of the ḥadīth.

True Meaning:

The Prophet (ṣallallāhu ‘alayhi wa-ālihi wa-sallam) meant that everything in this month carries blessings, but this does not mean we should avoid active worship and self-improvement.

Solution:

Instead of wasting Ramadhān in sleep, balance rest and worship. Use the nights for du‘ā’, Qur’ānic reflection, and sincere repentance.

Disconnect from the Qur'ān

The True Ramadhān:

The Qur'ān was revealed in this month, and we are encouraged to reflect deeply on its message.

The Ahl al-Bayt (‘alayhimus-salām) emphasized learning and implementing Qur'ānic teachings in daily life.

Our Ramadhān in the Subcontinent:

Many people recite the Qur'ān without understanding its meaning. The older generation prioritizes recitation in Arabic while ignoring its meaning and practical application.

Solution:

Read with understanding—learn the meaning of the verses.

Implement at least one lesson from the Qur'ān daily.

Justice for Laborers and Workers

True Islamic Justice:

Islam teaches balance in fasting and working.

The Prophet (ṣallallāhu ‘alayhi wa-ālihi wa-sallam) ensured fair treatment of workers.

Issue in the Subcontinent:

Many laborers and physically demanding workers are forced to work long hours in extreme conditions, making fasting unbearable.

Some are pushed to exhaustion and end up breaking their fasts.

Solution:

Employers should reduce working hours for physically demanding jobs.

Community support should be given to those struggling financially during this month.

Conclusion: Restoring the True Spirit of Ramadhān

Key Lessons for a More Meaningful Ramadhān:

- ★ Ramadhān is a divine opportunity—not a burden, but a means of purification.
- ★ Fasting is about self-control, not just hunger.
- ★ Women should not be overburdened—Ramadhān is for their spiritual growth too.
- ★ Misinterpretation of reward (sleeping all day) should be corrected.
- ★ Charity should be done sincerely, without showing off.
- ★ Laborers should have reduced work hours for a manageable fast.

- ★ Spiritual transformation should last beyond Ramadhān.
- ★ Laylat al-Qadr should be deeply valued and prepared for.
- ★ The end of Ramadhān should be met with gratitude and reflection, not just Eid celebrations.

If we revive the true purpose of Ramadhān, it will become a transformative experience rather than just a ritual.